



If group health coverage isn't available to you, buy an individual policy, but be prepared to pay dearly for it. Research your options and compare benefits and costs. If you're in good health, consider buying a policy with a higher deductible to cover you in the event of a serious illness. You'll pay less for it but you could incur out-of-pocket costs up to the deductible amount.

What about COBRA?

Under the Consolidated Omnibus Budget Reconciliation Act (COBRA) of 1986, employees who lose medical and dental insurance for certain reasons can often buy group coverage for themselves and their dependents for a specified period of time at group rates. The law applies to group health plans maintained by private sector and state and local government employers with twenty or more full- and part-time employees in the prior year. It doesn't apply to plans maintained by the federal government or church organizations.

To be eligible, you must experience a qualifying event. These events as applied to the employees, as well as their spouses and dependents, are outlined in the COBRA Insurance Continuation chart.

▼ COBRA INSURANCE CONTINUATION

Qualifying Event	Beneficiary	Coverage Period
Termination of employment; reduced hours	Employee, spouse; dependent child	18 months
Employee entitled to Medicare; divorce or legal separation; death of covered employee	Spouse, dependent child	36 months
Loss of dependent child status	Dependent child	36 months